

The Icy Defender

Nila B. Smith

1 In 1812, Napoleon Bonaparte, **Emperor** of the French, led his Grand Army into Russia. He was prepared for the **fierceⁱ resistance** of the Russian people defending their homeland. He was prepared for the long **marchⁱⁱ** across Russian soil to Moscow, the capital city. But he was not prepared for the **devastatingⁱⁱⁱ** enemy that met him in Moscow -- the **raw, bitter, bleak** Russian winter.

- i. Fierce means intense, powerful, 顽强的;
- ii. If we capitalise the **Long March**, it refers particularly to “Chang Zheng.” 大写的 Long March 是一个专有名词，特指红军长征；
- iii. Devastating means highly destructive, extremely powerful 极具摧毁力的；
- iv. Raw 本身表示生肉，此处是其罕见用法，表示 unpleasantly cold or damp; bitter means raw, harsh, cold; bleak means raw, bleak. 这三个词均表相同含义。

2 In 1941, Adolf Hitler, leader of Nazi Germany, **launched^v** an attack against the Soviet Union, as Russia then was called. Hitler's military **might^{vi}** was **unequaled^{vii}**. His war machine had **mowed down^{viii}** resistance in most of Europe. Hitler expected a short **campaign(=war)** but, like Napoleon before him, was **taught a painful lesson**. The Russian winter again came to the **aid** of the Soviet soldiers.

- v. Launch 在英语中的使用是非常广泛的。We can say “launch a project,” (=start a project) “launch a rocket,” (=release a rocket 发射) “launch a product,” (投放) “launch a war/attack/campaign/activity,” etc.
- vi. Might here is a noun. Its adjective is mighty; the adverb is mightily.
- vii. Unequaled has many synonyms, such as unparalleled, matchless, incomparable, unrivaled 无与伦比的，无法匹敌的；
- viii. Mow down means to kill or destroy in great numbers mercilessly.

Napoleon's Campaign

3 In the spring of 1812, Napoleon **assembled** an army of six hundred thousand men **on the borders of** Russia. The soldiers were well trained, efficient, and well-equipped. This military force was called the Grand Army. Napoleon, confident of a quick victory, **predicted** the **conquest^{ix}** of Russia in five weeks.

- ix. The verb form of conquest is conquer. Conquest means the act of conquering or something that is conquered. 它既可以表示被征服之地，也可以表示征服这一举动。
例如：
The conquest expanded the boundaries of the kingdom. 这片降伏之地拓展了王国的疆土。

4 Shortly afterwards, Napoleon's army crossed the Neman River into Russia. The quick, **decisive** victory that Napoleon expected never happened. To his surprise, the Russians refused to stand and fight. Instead, they **retreated** eastward, burning their crops and homes as they went. The Grand Army followed, but its advance march soon became **bogged down^x** by slow-moving supply lines.

- x. Bog down literally means to cause something to sink in wet ground, 本身表示让某

物陷入湿地，这里是它的比喻义，我们理解为速度急剧放缓。原文 its advance march soon became bogged down by slow-moving supply lines 可以转译为：its march was soon stuck because the supply lines moved too slowly.

5 In August, the French and Russian armies **engaged**^{xi} at Smolensk, in a battle that left over ten thousand dead on each side. Yet, the Russians were again able to **retreat** farther into Russian **territory**. Napoleon had won no decisive victory. He was now faced with a **crucial** decision. Should he continue to **pursue(chase)** the Russian army? Or should he keep his army in Smolensk for the **approaching**^{xii} winter?

xi. Engage 是一个非常重要的词汇，该词要学会应用。本科阶段需要掌握它三种用法：1) attract, involve, 表示吸引， e.g. Her voice engaged my attention. 2) enter into combat or conflict with an enemy. 交火. 3) to bind by a pledge to marry 订婚, e.g. He was engaged to the princess of Turkey. = He was bound by a pledge to marry the princess of Turkey.

xii. The approaching winter means the coming winter, the near winter.

6 Napoleon **took the gamble** of **pressing on to**^{xiii} Moscow, 448 kilometers away. On September 7, 1812, the French and Russian armies met in fierce battle at Borodino, 112 kilometers west of Moscow. By **nightfall**, thirty thousand French and forty-four thousand Russians **lay**^{ixx} dead or **wounded** on the battlefield.

xiii. Take the gamble means to do something risky or by chance that might fail in the end. Press on to a place 表示大军压境某一地方；

ixx. Lie dead or wounded 表示躺平在地上的状态，这个状态既可以是 dead，也可以是 wounded. So here, lie means to be in a horizontal position.

7 Again, the Russian army retreated to safety. Napoleon had a clear path to Moscow, but the occupation of the city became an empty victory. The Russians **fled(=escaped)** their capital. Soon after the French arrived, a **raging**^{xx} fire destroyed two-thirds of the city. Napoleon offered a **truce(休战书)** to Alexander I, but the Russian czar knew he could **bide his time**^{xxi}: "We shall let the Russian winter fight the war for us."

xx. Raging means violent or forceful, very severe and intense. Raging fire 表示烈火；

xxi. Bide one's time is a fixed phrase; it means to wait for further deployment 等待进一步计划；

8 Napoleon soon realized he could not **feed(=provide food for)**, **clothe(=provide clothes for)**, and **quarter(=provide shelter for)** his army in Moscow during the winter. In October 1812, he ordered his Grand Army to retreat from Moscow.

9 The French retreat turned into a **nightmare**. From fields and forests, the Russians launched **hit-and-run attacks** on the French. A short distance from Moscow, the temperature had already dropped to minus 4 degrees Celsius. On November 3, the winter's first snow came. **Exhausted(=weary, tired, fatigued)** horses fell dead in their tracks. Cannon became stuck in the snow. Equipment had to be burned for fuel. Soldiers took ill and froze to death. The French soldiers **dragged on**, leaving the dead along every mile.

10 As the Russian army was gathering its strength, the French had to flee Russia to avoid certain defeat. At the Berezina River, the Russians nearly **trapped**^{xxii} the retreating French by

burning the bridges over the **swollen**(=overwhelming, flooding) river. But Napoleon, by a **stroke of luck**^{xxiii}, was able to build two new bridges. Thousands of French soldiers escaped, but at the cost of fifty thousand dead. Once across the Berezina, the **tattered**(shabby, ragged 残破不堪, 东倒西歪的) survivors **limped**(跛行) toward Vilna.

xxii. Trap here simply means to prevent the French troops from escaping.

xxiii. A stroke of luck 一丝运气, 同学们还可以说 a stroke of humour, 一抹幽默; a stroke of madness = an impulse of madness, 突发的一阵疯狂。

11 Of the six hundred thousand soldiers Napoleon had led into Russia, less than one hundred thousand came back. The **weakened**^{xxiv} French army continued its retreat westward across Europe. Soon, Britain, Austria, Russia, and Prussia formed a powerful **alliance**^{xxv} and attacked these **stragglers**. In March 1814, Paris was captured. Napoleon **abdicated**^{xxvi} and **went into exile**, his **empire** at an end.

xxiv. Weaken 的后缀是-en, 表示使某词动词化。类似的词汇还有 strength, strengthen / length, lengthen / wide, widen / deep, deepen / short, shorten / soft, soften / light, lighten / tight, tighten 等;

xxv. Alliance is the state of being allied or united, a bond.抽象概念, 意为**联合**; Ally, as a verb, means unite; as a noun, it means a partner, a helper.具象概念, 意为**盟友**;

xxvi. Abdicate means renounce or give up one's throne 放弃王位, 退位。Exile means a period of forced absence from one's hometown. E.g. Su Dongpo was forced to go into exile.

Hitler's Invasion

12 By early 1941, Adolf Hitler, leader of Nazi Germany, had **seized**(=captured) control of most of Europe. To the east of Hitler's German empire was the Soviet Union. On June 22, 1941, without a **declaration of war**(宣战), Hitler began an invasion of the Soviet Union that was the largest military land **campaign**^{xxvii} in history. Confident of a quick victory, Hitler expected the campaign to last no longer than three months. He planned to use the blitzkrieg, or "lightning war," **tactics** that had **defeated** the rest of Europe. The invasion had three broad **thrusts**: against Leningrad and Moscow and through the Ukraine.

xxvii. Campaign means a connected series of military operations forming a distinct phase of war.作为名词, 它表示某一时期的一系列连串的军事行动; 在原文中, 其含义和 invasion, war, offensive, advance 基本同义。

Campaign 除了战役, 还有另一更常见的用法, 它表示 an organised course of action or a connected series of operations designed to achieve a goal. 为达到某一目的而展开的一系列有组织或有序列的行为。例如: an election campaign, 选举活动; an advertising campaign, 指的是包含设计、策划、执行、预算、时间和场地安排的广告活动。

我们来进行**词形辨析**:

Campaign / Champaign / Champagne

Champaign means plain, 表示平原, 或平坦的;

Champagne 表示香槟酒。

大家注意区分。

13 **Caught off guard**^{xxviii} by the invasion, Soviet leader Joseph Stalin **instructed** the Russian people to "**scorch** the earth" in front of the German invaders. Farms and factories were

burned, destroyed, or **rendered**^{xxix} useless. During the first ten weeks of the invasion, the Germans pushed the front eastward, and the Russians suffered more than a million **casualties**(该词通常用复数, 因为战争的死伤一般大于一人).

xxviii. Catch sb off guard: to surprise sb by doing something they are not expecting. E.g.

I was caught completely off guard when my friend announced her wedding date. (真是一把狗粮撒的猝不及防啊。)

xxix. 本科阶段同学们需至少记忆 render 这个词的两种含义: 1) make, 致使, 这层含义使用最为广泛。E.g. The heavy rains rendered his escape impossible. 原文的 Factories were rendered useless, 就等于 Factories were made useless. 2) translate, 翻译。Render this French book into English.

14 In the north, the Germans **closed in on**(=besiege, 围困) Leningrad. Despite great suffering, however, the people of Leningrad refused to **surrender**(=give up, yield). As the battle of Leningrad dragged on into winter, the city's situation became **desperate**^{xxx}. As food ran out, people died from hunger and disease. By the middle of the winter of 1941 to 1942, nearly four thousand people **starved to death** every day. Close to one million people died as a result of the **siege**.

xxx. Desperate here means giving no ground for hope, having lost hope, full of despair.

深感绝望的;

15 In the center of Russia, Hitler's goal was the **capture**(=seize) of Moscow. Because the Germans had **anticipated** a quick victory, they had made no plans for winter supplies. October arrived with heavy rains. "General Mud" slowed down the movement of the Germans' lightning attack.

16 As Hitler's armies **drew**(=moved towards) closer and closer to Moscow, an early, severe winter **settled over**^{xxxi} the Soviet Union, the **harsh**^{est}(=the rawest, the most austere, 最严酷的) in years. Temperatures dropped to minus 48 degrees Celsius. Heavy snows fell. The German soldiers, completely unprepared for the Russian winter, froze in their light summer uniforms. The German tanks lay buried in the heavy snowbanks. The Russian winter brought the German **offensive**(进攻) to a **halt**(=stop, stalemate).

xxxi. 此处是该词不常见用法。It means to sink or descend gradually, 逐渐降临, 降落,

下沉。E.g. Darkness settled over the fields.

17 By the summer of 1942, Hitler had launched two new offensives. In the south, the Germans captured Sevastopol. Hitler then pushed east to Stalingrad, a great industrial city that **stretched**(=extended) for 48 kilometers along the Volga River. Despite great suffering, Soviet defenders refused to give up Stalingrad.

18 In November 1942, the Russians launched a **counterattack**. With little or no shelter from the winter cold in and around Stalingrad, German troops were further weakened by a lack of food and supplies. Not until January 1943 did the Germans give up their siege. Of the three hundred thousand Germans attacking Stalingrad, only ninety thousand **starving** soldiers were left. The loss of the battle for Stalingrad finally **turned the tide against**(=change or reverse something dramatically 扭转局面) Hitler. The German victories were over, thanks in part to the Russian winter.

19 During 1943 and 1944, the Soviet armies pushed the German front back toward the west. In the north, the Red Army broke the three-year siege of Leningrad with a surprise attack on January 15, 1944. Within two weeks, the **heroic survivors** of Leningrad saw their invaders **depart**(=leave, retreat 离开, 撤离). By March 1944, the Ukraine farming region was again in Soviet hands. On May 9, 1944, Sevastopol was **liberated**^{xxxii} from the Germans. The Russians were now **heading for**(=going towards 朝某处进发) Berlin.

xxxii. PLA represents People's Liberation Army, 解放军;

20 For Hitler, the invasion of the Soviet Union had turned into a military disaster. For the Russian people, it brought **unspeakable**^{xxxiii} suffering. The total Soviet dead in World War II reached almost 23 million.

xxxiii. 我们此处做一个词义辨析:

Unspeakable means beyond description, inexpressible, inexpressibly bad 无法言说的, 用来形容糟糕的情况;

Speechless 通常表示因惊讶、诧异而无语, 表示 silent。

E.g. Einstein suffered an unspeakable pain when his wife passed away.

I remained speechless at his arrogance. 我对他的骄傲自大无言以对。

21 The **elements**^{xxxiv} of nature must be **reckoned with**(=taken into consideration) in any military campaign. Napoleon and Hitler both **underestimated** the **severity** of the Russian winter. Snow, ice, and freezing temperatures **took their toll on**^{xxxv} both invading armies. For the Russian people, the winter was an icy defender.

xxxiv. 大家注意, 此处的 elements 不表示元素, 因素。这里的 elements 是特殊用法, 特指 violent or severe weather conditions. 恶劣的天气, **必须加 s**;

xxxv. Take a toll on sb means to cause damage, to have a cumulative negative effect on. 同学们要学会看英英释义, 这个词组的含义是“带来损害, 带来持续积累的负面影响。”所以原文表示 Snow, ice, and freezing temperatures gradually caused damage to the invading armies.